

RANA SIVRAJ



Hanging By a Thread

CHANDIGARH The recent trans-border euphoria over the release of Kashmir Singh from a Pakistan prison after 35 years of detention has proved to be short-lived. The Pakistan Government has cleared the decks for the execution of Sarabjit Singh, who was arrested from Multan in September, 1990, in the wake of four bomb blasts across Pakistan that had killed 14 people.

Pakistan claims that

Sarabjit is Manjit Singh from Bhikhiwind near Amritsar. He was charged with complicity in the blasts and sentenced to death by the Lahore High Court in 2003. Later, the Pakistan Supreme Court had turned down his clemency plea and upheld his conviction on the basis of his "confession" of being an operator of the RAW, India's external intelligence agency. Sarabjit's family insists that he was a victim of mistaken iden-

ON A WING AND PRAYER: Sarabjit's family

tity and had strayed into the Pakistani territory in an inebriated state.

Sarabjit's mercy plea was rejected by Pakistan President Pervez Musharraf, prompting the Interior Ministry to issue the death warrant and fix April 1 as the date for his hanging. Seemingly, Sarabjit's fate was sealed after India handed over the body of a Pakistani national Khalid Mehmood at Wagah on March 12. Mehmood, a Pakistani national, had come to India to watch the India-Pakistan cricket match at Mohali in 2005. He went missing but was arrested in Haryana in 2006 and died of ulcer as a prisoner in a Faridabad jail.

Also, Kashmir Singh's open confession after his return to India that he had been a spy added to the public fury in Pakistan as he was projected by the human rights activists as an innocent Indian national. With time running out for Sarabjit, efforts to save him from the death are on a wing and a prayer. **by Ramesh Vinayak**

SIGNPOSTS

RECOGNISED: By Tamil Nadu, the **third gender**, allowing 40,000 of the state's transsexuals to be officially accepted as a gender apart from 'male' and 'female'.

APPOINTED: Ex-BCCI president and Indian Premier League board member



Inderjit Singh Bindra as the International Cricket Council's principal adviser.

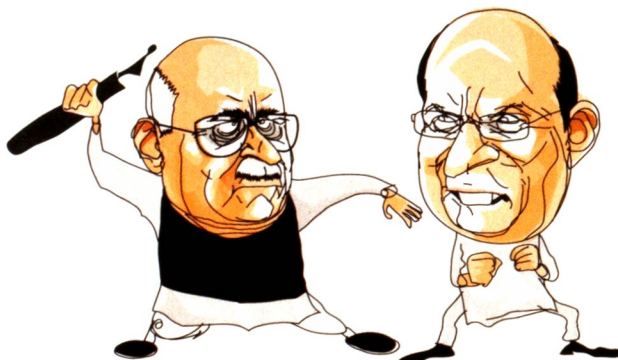
SELECTED: Kalamandalam **Gopi**, kathakali exponent and former principal of Kerala Kalamandalam, for the 2007 Kerala state Kathakali Puraskaram.

ELECTED: Ramendra Debnath, as the 10th Speaker of the Tripura legislative assembly. This will be his second term.

AWARDED: To the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, the Indira Gandhi Prize for Peace, Disarmament and Development for 2007.

VIS-A-VIS **L.K. ADVANI** leader of the Opposition **versus** **ABHISHEK SINGHVI** Congress spokesperson

The UPA's biggest achievements were promoting corruption, criminalisation, minorityism and apathy for internal security.



The BJP-led NDA government had established milestones in scams and scandals, from Tehelka to Hudco.

EPILOGUE: Accusations are indicative of the fact that parties have started gearing up for the polls.